Card retry schedules

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When a recurring card payment fails, PayRail can retry it automatically. This page explains which failures are retried, the default schedule, how to set a custom schedule, and the webhooks you receive.

Soft and hard declines

A **soft decline** is temporary: insufficient funds, a limit reached, or the issuer unavailable. Soft declines are retried. A **hard decline** is permanent: a lost or stolen card, a closed account, or a card reported as fraudulent. Hard declines are never retried, whatever the schedule, and PayRail sends `payment.retry_exhausted` straight away.

Default schedule

Every account starts on the default schedule. A failed payment is retried three times:

Retry	When
1	1 day after the failure
2	3 days after the failure
3	5 days after the failure

Each retry is a new charge attempt and may appear on the cardholder's statement as a pending authorisation.

Custom schedules

Set a custom schedule under *Settings › Recurring › Retries*, or with the `retry_schedule` field on the account API. A custom schedule has between 1 and 10 retries, all within 14 days of the failure. Changes apply to failures from the next day; payments already being retried keep their old schedule.

Smart timing

With **smart timing** on, PayRail may move a retry by up to 24 hours towards a time the issuer is more likely to approve, such as a common payday. It never moves a retry outside the schedule's last day. Smart timing is off by default.

Webhooks

`payment.retry_scheduled`: sent each time a retry is booked, with its date. `payment.retry_succeeded`: a retry was approved. `payment.retry_exhausted`: no retries remain, or the decline was hard.

Grace periods

PayRail does not hold or release anything on your behalf. If your product gives customers a grace period after the last retry, start it from `payment.retry_exhausted` and manage it in your own system.

PayRail is a fictional company. This document is test data.